

The Washington Post

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Hazy, warm 87/66 • Tomorrow: Partly sunny 85/67 B6

Democracy Dies in Darkness

WEDNESDAY, JUNE 4, 2025 • \$4

Kennedy Center sees drop in sales

After Trump takeover, subscription revenue is down 36% year over year

BY TRAVIS M. ANDREWS

Sales of subscriptions for the coming season of programming at the Kennedy Center for the Performing Arts are down by about \$1.6 million, or roughly 36 percent, compared with last year.

By this point in 2024, the center had generated \$4,413,147 in revenue from selling subscriptions to its theater, dance, classical and other seasons of performances. This year, it has generated \$2,656,524 as of June 1, plus \$155,243 from a new mix-and-match package, according to internal data obtained by The Washington Post.

The sales data was collected and shared by former Kennedy Center employees and confirmed by a current staff member, who spoke on the condition of anonymity out of fear of retribution. The subscription data offers a window into the center's overall finances but is just one source of revenue, in addition to donations, individual ticket sales, government funding and other sources. Its operating budget in 2024 was \$268 million. Of that, roughly \$125 million came from earned revenue, such as ticket sales.

"We understand providing information like this can be seen in a bad light," the current staffer says. SEE KENNEDY CENTER ON A18



The buzz about eradicating mosquitoes

Gene editing may allow scientists to eliminate the pests. Should they?

BY DINO GRANDONI

They buzz, they bite, and they cause some of the deadliest diseases known to humanity. Mosquitoes are perhaps the planet's most universally reviled animals.

If we could zap them off the face of the Earth, should we?

The question is no longer hypothetical. In recent years, scientists have devised powerful genetic tools that may be able to eradicate mosquitoes and other pests once and for all.

Now, some doctors and scientists say it is time to take the extraordinary step of unleashing gene editing to suppress mosquitoes and avoid human suffering from malaria, dengue, West Nile virus and other serious diseases.

"There are so many lives at stake with malaria that we want to see MOSQUITOES ON A7

After months of political chaos, a decisive election in South Korea



JINTAK HAN/THE WASHINGTON POST

Supporters of Lee Jae-myung, presidential candidate for the Democratic Party of Korea, gather Monday in Seoul for his final campaign rally before Tuesday's election. Lee defeated conservative Kim Moon-soo in his bid to succeed Yoon Suk Yeol, who was impeached and removed from office after declaring martial law. **Story, A8**

Musk labels Trump's tax measure an 'abomination'

BY JACOB BOGAGE AND THEODORIC MEYER

Billionaire Elon Musk blasted the massive tax and immigration bill at the heart of President Donald Trump's agenda on Tuesday, calling the measure "a disgusting abomination" that would burden the country with "crushingly unsustainable debt."

Though Musk — who on Friday left his post as head of the U.S. DOGE Service, Trump's cost-

cutting effort — had previously criticized the bill in gentler terms, his posts on X, the social media platform he owns, represented his sharpest attack yet on the Trump White House. For months, Musk had played the role of the president's "first buddy," joining Trump frequently in the Oval Office and exhorting the administration to cut government spending.

The posts appeared to complicate the path to passage for the

legislation, which barely passed the House late last month after conservatives revolted over its enormous price tag. The nonpartisan Congressional Budget Office says the bill would increase the national debt by \$2.4 trillion over the next decade. The Senate began consideration of the measure this week, and GOP leaders hope to have it to Trump's desk by July 4. Trump has encouraged lawmakers to pass the measure, but some Republican Senate budget

hawks applauded Musk's attack Tuesday, a potential sign of trouble.

"This massive, outrageous, pork-filled Congressional spending bill is a disgusting abomination," Musk posted on X. "Shame on those who voted for it: you know you did wrong. You know it."

He wrote minutes later: "It will massively increase the already gigantic budget deficit to \$2.5 trillion (!!!) and burden America SEE MUSK ON A4

Kyiv's drone feat underscores a U.S. vulnerability

BY ELLEN NAKASHIMA AND WARREN P. STROBEL

Ukraine's surprise Sunday strike that used relatively inexpensive drones to knock out a significant portion of Russia's long-range bomber capability was arguably the single largest blow to Moscow in its three-year war on its neighbor and a stunning display of asymmetric warfare.

The out-of-the-blue drone blitz elicited glee among Ukraine's backers in Washington, but also a chilling realization: The United States is increasingly vulnerable to just such a low-tech, low-cost strike.

"The Pentagon should be very worried about this," said Stacie Pettyjohn, a senior fellow at the Center for a New American Security who focuses on drone warfare

and nuclear deterrence. A Ukraine-style attack — using drones hidden in shipping containers or trucks — could very well happen on U.S. soil, or against U.S. air and naval bases overseas, she said.

"Any country that has strategic bombers, strategic missiles and silos, or strategic nuclear submarines at port is looking at the attack and thinking the risk to

our arsenal from a containerized set of drones disguised as a semitrailer poses a real risk," said Jason Matheny, CEO of the Rand Corporation and a former director of the Intelligence Advanced Research Projects Activity, which develops advanced technologies SEE WARFARE ON A9

Crimean Bridge: Ukraine bombs a key Russian supply route. **A9**



OKSANA PARAFENIUK/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Olena Matvienko journeyed deep into Russia to retrieve her grandson Illia, whose mother was killed.

A test case for saving Ukraine's lost children

Tens of thousands have vanished into Russia

BY LIZZIE JOHNSON AND KOSTIANTYN KHUDOV

UZHGOROD, UKRAINE — The boy from Mariupol still wasn't ready to walk to the bus stop alone, so just before 8 a.m., he and his grandmother set off for school together. He reached for her hand, zipping her fingers in his own, and stole a sip of her coffee.

Illia Matvienko was almost 13 but still got lost easily. Three years had passed since his mother bled out in his arms after a Russian shelling, since a neighbor chipped her grave in the frozen winter of their yard, since soldiers found him alone and took him deeper into the occupied Donetsk territory, where he

was put up for adoption.

There, he almost became a different boy: a Russian one.

Until his grandmother, Olena Matvienko, spotted him in a 26-second Russian propaganda video. Illia became an extraordinary test case for how, and whether, Ukraine could claw back its missing children — a journey that took Olena across four international borders and deep into Russia.

"I wouldn't have found him if I didn't see the video," Olena, 64, said during three days of interviews last month at their home in Uzhhorod, in far western Ukraine. "He would be with a different family now. How much would he remember of who he

SEE UKRAINE ON A10

IN THE NEWS

Tulsa Race Massacre The city's mayor announced \$105 million in reparations for the 1921 attack that left 300 Black people dead. **A3**

Boulder attack The wife and five children of the man accused of hurling molotov cocktails at marchers were taken into ICE custody for expedited deportations from the U.S. **A5**

THE NATION A federal judge halted a ban on providing hormone treatment to transgender inmates. **A2**
A new presidential portrait bears similarities to Donald Trump's mug shot in Georgia. **A4**

THE WORLD A consulting firm withdrew its team from the U.S.-backed aid delivery program in Gaza. **A11**
The Dutch government collapsed as the leader of a right-wing party left the ruling coalition. **A12**

THE ECONOMY The White House is likely to face bipartisan opposition to a proposed shutdown of the Chemical Safety Board. **A14**
In Japan, there is concern over what a Nippon Steel deal and doubled U.S. tariffs could mean for the two nations' relationship. **A18**

THE REGION D.C. police have withdrawn a request to bar people from celebrating Pride in the park at Dupont Circle this weekend. **B1**
The D.C. Council voted to pause the \$2 wage increase for restaurant workers that was set to begin July 1. **B1**

STYLE Tony nominee Latanya Richardson Jackson didn't pursue stardom, but she found it on Broadway. **C1**

FOOD How well do you know the sources of major U.S. food imports? Test your knowledge with a quiz. **E1**

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COMICS.....C4
OBITUARIES.....B4
OPINION PAGES.....A15
TELEVISION.....C5
WORLD NEWS.....A8

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